Religion

04/10/25

Religion is a range of socio-cultural systems including behaviors and practices, morals, beliefs, worldviews, texts, sanctified places, prophecies, ethics or organizations, that generally relate humanity to supernatural, transcendental and spiritual elements.

* The term "religion" comes from both old French and Anglo-Norman (1200s CE) and means respect for sense of right, moral obligation, sanctity, what is sacred, reverence for the gods.

Types of Religions based on beliefs

- Monotheistic (one God)
  - Sikhism
  - Zoroastrianism
  - Abrahmic religions
    - Judaism
    - Christianity
    - Islam
- Polytheistic (Many Gods)
  - Hindu
  - Shinto
  - Ancient (Greek/Egyptian)
- Animistic (Nature/spirit based)
  - Traditional Religions
  - Afro-American Religions
  - Nature-based Religions
  - Tribal Religions
- Non-theistic/Philosophical
  - B J C T

B = Buddhism, J = Jainism,
C = Confucianism, T = Taoism

Religions are often classified by how they view the divine (Gods / Spirits).

1. Abrahmic Religions –

Origin – Middle East (West asia)
Comman link – Traces spiritual lineage to Abraham
Traits – Monotheism (belief in one god), scriptures, prophets, salvation history

Key faiths –

(a) Judaism – Oldest Abrahmic faith, began around 2000 BCE. It emphasizes one god (yahweh), ethical living and adherence to the Torah (sacred law).

(b) Christianity – Grew out of judaism in 1st century CE, centered on life, death. Central message is salvation through faith, love and grace.

(c) Islam – Founded in 7th century CE in Arabia by prophet Muhammad. Quran is the holy book, and its core pillars include faith, prayer, charity.

2. Dharmic / Indian Religions –

Origin: Indian Subcontinent
Key faiths: Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism
Traits - Concept of Dharma (duty/order), karma, rebirth, liberation (Moksha / Nirvana

Key Faiths -

1. Hinduism - Evolved over thousand of years with no single founder. It is diverse, encompassing devotion to many deities (like Vishnu, Shiva, Devi), philosophies and rituals.

2. Buddhism - 5th century BCE with teachings of Siddhartha Gautama (the Buddha) in India. It rejects caste distinctions and focuses on ending sufferings (dukkha) through four noble truths.

3. Jainism - 6th century BCE by Mahavira. Strict Non-violence (ahimsa), truth and self discipline as path to liberation.

4. Sikhism - 15th century Punjab, founded by Guru Nanak and developed through ten Sikh gurus. It emphasis

devotion to one god, equality and community service.

3. Chinese Religions –

Origin – Ancient China
Traits – Harmony with Nature, ancestor veneration, balance of social and cosmic order.

Key faiths –

(a) Confucianism – Based on teachings of Confucius (551 – 479 BCE). It emphasizes moral cultivation, respect for elders and education.

(b) Taoism (Daoism) – Rooted in teachings of Laozi and texts like Tao Te Ching. Symbolised by Yin – Yang.

4. Other world religions & Indigenous traditions –

Traits – Often polytheistic / animistic, tied to land, ancestors and local communities.

Key faiths – African traditional religions, Shinto (Japan)

(a) Zoroastrianism – Originated in Persia by

Prophet Zoroaster (Zarathustra), this faith worship Ahura Mazda as the Supreme God.

Categories description —

1. Monotheism → Belief in one God

2. Polytheism → Belief in Many god/deities

3. Animism → Belief that spirits or divine forces exists in Nature (trees, rivers, animals, mountain).

4. Atheistic/Non-theistic → Religions that do not emphasize God/gods, but focus on philosophy, ethics or self liberation.

Table —

Category	Religion	Origin (Time & place)	Founder/ Key figure	Sacred Texts	Followers	Core Beliefs/ Symbols
Abrahamic	Judaism	2000 BCE, Middle East	Abraham, Moses	Torah, Tanakh	Jews	One God (Yahweh), Covenant, law

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Abrahamic	Christianity	1st c. CE, Palestine	Jesus Christ	Bible (Old & New Testament	Christians	Salvation through Christ, Cross ✝
	Islam	7th c. CE, Arabia	Prophet Muhammad	Quran, Hadith	Muslims	One God (Allah), Five Pillars ☪
Dharmic	Hinduism	1500 BCE +, India	No single founder	Vedas, Gita, Upanishads	Hindus	Dharma, Karma, Moksha, Om ॐ
	Buddhism	5th c. BCE India	Siddhartha Gautama (Buddha)	Tripitaka, Suttras	Buddhists	Four Noble Truths, Nirvana
	Jainism	6th c. BCE India	Mahavira (24th Tirthankara)	Agamas	Jains	Ahimsa (Non-violence), Moksha, Truth, Ahimsa hand with wheel

	Sikhism	15th C.CE, Punjab	Guru Nanak & 10 Gurus	Guru Granth Sahib	Sikhs	One God, Equality, Seva
Chinese	Confucianism	5th C. BCE China	Confucius	Analects	Confucians	Ethics, order, Filial piety
	Taoism	4th C. BCE China	Laozi (Lao Tzu)	Tao Te Ching	Taoists	Harmony with Tao, Yin Yang
Other	Zoroastrianism	1200–600 BCE, Persia	Zoroaster, Zarathustra	Avesta	Zoroastrians	Dualism: Ahura Mazda vs Angra Mainyu, Fire
	Shinto	Ancient Japan	No single founder	Kojiki, Nihon Shoki	Shintoists	Kami (spirits), purity rituals
	African traditio	Prehistoric	Tribal ancestors	Oral tradition	Varied tribes	Animism (Nature

nal religion	africa				worship, ancestral spirits, good and bad spirits, Diverse traditions, Balance with Nature

Type of religious groups –

1. Cult – A small, new or unorthodox religious group, often led by a charismatic leader.

* often seen as outside mainstream society

Example – Heaven's gate (US)

2. Sect – A subgroup that breaks away from a larger religious tradition due to differences in beliefs or practices.

* Maintains most of parent religion's core beliefs but has distinctive practices.

Example – Amish (from Christianity)

3. Denomination – A recognized, organized branch of a major religion with its own institutions and practices.

- Larger, formalized, part of mainstream religion

  Example- Roman Catholicism (Christianity), Sunni Islam, Reform Judaism

4. Church- A large, established religious organization with a formal structure and community of followers.

- Considered mainstream, often politically and socially influential.

  Example - Church of England

5. New Religious Movement (NRM) - A recently founded religion or spiritual group, often with innovative beliefs or practices.

- Can start as a cult and grow into denomination over time.

  Example - Scientology, Bahá'í Faith

6. Congregation - A local group of worshippers who meet regularly in a place of worship.

- Can belong to a denomination or church;

focuses on community worship.

Example - a local parish, Mosque or Synagogue

Table -

	Type	Size	Relation to Main Religion	Example
1.	Cult	Small	Outside mainstream	Heaven's Gate US
2.	Sect	Small - medium	Breaks from larger religion	Amish (from Christianity)
3.	Denomination	Large	part of mainstream	Roman Catholicism
4.	Church	Large	Mainstream, Established	Church of England
5.	NRM	Varies	New, innovative	Scientology, Baha'i
6.	Congregation	Local	Community worship, part of larger group	Parish, Church, mosque

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Religion in Anthropology -

* Religion is a universal cultural phenomenon found in all human societies.

* Anthropology studies origin, function and evolution of religion.

* It connects with belief systems, rituals, magic, myths, social order and symbols

Key concepts -

Magic - Individual attempt to control supernatural (e.g Trobriand Islanders)

Religion - Collective, rituals and beliefs in supernatural beings.

Science - Empirical, rational explanation of natural phenomena.

Myths - Sacred stories explaining origins, legitimizing authority.

Rituals - Symbolic acts (rites of passage, seasonal, fertility rituals).

Totemism (Durkheim) - Animals/plants as sacred symbols of clans.

Mana (Codrington) - Impersonal supernatural power.

Shamanism - Religious specialist (shaman) mediating with spirits.

Based on this concepts, anthropological

Classification is done –

Typology of religion (Anthropological Classification)

Type	Definition	Example
Animism	Belief in spirits of nature or ancestors	Tribes (Andamanese, Australian aboriginals)
Animatism	Belief in impersonal supernatural force (mana)	Polynesian cultures
Totemism	Sacred relationship between a group and a natural object	Australian tribes, Ojibwa
Polytheism	Belief in multiple gods	Ancient Greek religion, Hinduism
Monotheism	Belief in one God	Islam, Christianity
Monism/ philosophical religion	Belief in ultimate reality as one	Vedanta, Buddhism (Nirvana concept)

Anthropological Approaches to Religion —

Thinker	Approach	Key Ideas and Examples
E. B Tylor (1871)	Evolutionary (Animism)	Religion originates in belief in Soul / Spirits Animism → Polytheism → Monotheism → Science Ex- Andamanese tribes, Ancient Egyptians
James Frazer (1890)	Magic → Religion → Science	"Golden Bough" – Magic fails → People turn to religion → later replaced by Science. Ex- Trobriand magic, Ancient Roman rituals
Durkheim (1912	Functionalist	Religion unites people; distinction between Sacred and profane; rituals strengthen social solidarity. Ex- Australian aboriginals, Hindu festivals
Malinowski	Psycological	Religion and magic help

Thinker	Approach	Key Ideas and Examples
	Functionalism	reduce anxiety and uncertainty Ex- Tobriand fishing magic, Rainmaking rituals
Radcliffe-Brown	Structural-Functionalist	Rituals maintain social structure and continuity. Ex- African tribal rites, Japanese Shinto festival.
Clifford Geertz	Symbolic/ Interpretive	Religion = Cultural Systems or symbols giving meaning to life. Ex- Balinese Hinduism, Catholic Symbolism, Moroccan Islam, Jewish Passover rituals